

Draft Script

What does it mean to be a citizen of the world when the state you live in refuses to see you as an equal citizen at home?

Most of us take our citizenship for granted. We assume our rights are permanent shields given to us simply because we were born. But modern history reveals a darker reality: whenever political systems tie human dignity strictly to national borders, anyone falling between those borders finds their rights stripped away.

Three decades ago, philosopher Martha Nussbaum challenged us to dismantle this border-first thinking. In *Patriotism and Cosmopolitanism*, she argued that nationality is merely an accident of birth—in her words, a "morally irrelevant characteristic". Nussbaum insisted that our primary moral allegiance should belong not to state borders or sovereign flags, but to the worldwide community of human beings.

Yet our global order remains bound by national walls. And nowhere is the human cost of that failure clearer than right here in Bangladesh, in the five-decade struggle of the Urdu-speaking Bihari community.

[MONTAGE — 1947 PARTITION, 1971 WAR & MAKESHIFT CAMPS]

To understand this tragedy, we must ask: who are the Biharis?

They are an Urdu-speaking Muslim minority originally hailing from Bihar and neighboring regions in British India. In 1947, fleeing communal violence during Partition, hundreds of thousands migrated to East Bengal as recognized Pakistani citizens, building lives, raising families, and working across railways and industry.

Then came their catastrophic second displacement. In 1971, Bangladesh fought its Liberation War to break free from Pakistani rule. During that brutal conflict, political and linguistic divisions left the Bihari community trapped on the losing side of history.

When Bangladesh was born, their world vanished beneath their feet. Branded collectively with the stigma of *dalal* or "collaborators," an estimated nine hundred thousand people were left stranded under the 1972 Citizenship Order. Pakistan abandoned them.

And as anthropologist Dina Siddiqi documents, the international community abandoned them as well: the UNHCR refused to recognize them as refugees simply because they had not crossed an international border after 1971. Falling through the cracks of the nation-state system, hundreds of thousands were pushed into temporary settlements—evolving into the roughly seventy squalid camps that have confined three generations for over fifty years.

Why did this happen? Why couldn't our political systems see their shared humanity?

As Benedict Anderson observed, modern nations are *imagined communities* built through shared language and national symbols. Post-1971 nation-building rallied around Bengali linguistic identity—basing belonging on *ethnos*, on shared blood and language, rather than *demos*, the democratic rights of everyone living on this soil. To define who belonged inside that national brotherhood, an internal "Other" was created and the Urdu-speaking Bihari became the outsider trapped inside our own cities.

Communitarian thinkers like Michael Walzer argue that states have an absolute right to control their borders and decide who belongs. But political theorist Andrew Linklater refutes this. Linklater shows that when states tie rights strictly to national identity, vulnerable internal minorities are stripped of all protection—reduced to what Hannah Arendt called the loss of "the right to have rights".

To solve this, Linklater introduces two vital pillars: **Cosmopolitan Rights** and **Cosmopolitan Duties**.

Cosmopolitan Rights insist that human dignity cannot be held hostage by state charity or ethnic membership. Every person possesses inalienable legal personhood and fundamental rights simply because they are human. In return, Cosmopolitan Duty places a direct moral obligation on the state guided by the Harm Principle to protect vulnerable populations within its borders rather than leaving them in structural neglect.

For the youth born inside Geneva Camp, cosmopolitanism is not an abstract theory; it is the real, tangible taste of freedom. Freedom begins when a residential address stops defining your human worth. It means holding an unblocked passport, securing a formal job, opening a bank account, and walking out of the camp's narrow lanes knowing your voice, your dignity, and your future are recognized without fear or stigma.

[MONTAGE — 2008 COURT RULING & REJECTED PASSPORT APPLICATION]

The community refused to remain passive victims. Following decades of youth mobilization, a preliminary court victory in 2003 paved the way for the landmark 2008 High Court ruling, legally affirming that camp residents born in Bangladesh are birthright citizens.

Statelessness was abolished on paper. But as researchers Khaled Hussain and Victoria Redclift demonstrate, winning rights on paper is not the same as having them in everyday life.

Today, Bihari youth hold national ID cards and vote in elections. Yet when they apply for passports, commercial bank accounts, or formal jobs, police verifications systematically reject them the moment their permanent address lists a "camp". The camp address has become an invisible internal border keeping them trapped in second-class citizenship.

[Closing]

A judicial verdict can grant formal rights on paper, but until our society dismantles administrative discrimination, cosmopolitan justice remains an unfinished promise. This is not a distant theoretical debate; it is an active test of global citizenship in our own society.

To see what this gap between paper law and lived reality actually looks like on the ground, I hand over to my teammate **Arnab**, who will take us directly inside the camps to examine the community's living conditions and daily infrastructure.

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